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The Carolina Raptor Center

The Raptor Center at Latta

Plantation park continues to offer a sanctuary and a place of refuge for the hunting birds known as raptors, and also starts the new year off with a new role. Since many species of birds are susceptible to the deadly West Nile virus the county's Health Department has asked the Raptor Center to monitor the extent of this virus by testing the birds that pass through its lab.

The virus is spread by mosquitoes and can infect birds as well as humans. First appearing in the US in 1992, the virus is thought to be responsible for the deaths of at least 7 people in the state of New York. The West Nile virus was discovered in October to have infected a crow in North Carolina, and the danger of future outbreaks in the state is very real according to Dennis Salmen, Mecklenburg County's expert on pest management.

Alan Barnhardt, Executive Director says: "Carolina Raptor Center is in a unique position to observe and supply blood and tissue samples to the Health Department. There are no similar organizations in the Carolinas that can provide this type of information. As a privately funded non-profit organization, we are pleased to provide such unique services to our community."

This month the Raptor Center will also host a program called *Raptors - Up Close and Personal*. At 1 and 2:30pm on the 20th, visitors are invited to participate in a behind-the-scenes look at the work of the Carolina Raptor Center, walk through the rehab center, and visit with the education birds and see how they are cared for. A CRC admission fee is required and, as space for such tours is limited, please reserve in advance by calling 704-875-6521, ext. 100.

Are you a Harry Potter fan?

The Carolina Raptor Center has two owls named for the messenger owls in the popular Harry Potter series of books by J.K. Rowling. Eastern screech owls Pigwidgeon and Hermes are new residents of the Raptor Center. In addition to visiting the birds, the Center's "Eagle's Landing" Gift Shop offers Harry Potter and Pigwidgeon miniatures for sale, as well as copies of the book *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire*.



Randall, RIP, November 24

A favorite with visitors to the Carolina Raptor Center, the barn owl Randall died on November 24 last year.

Randall was 16 years with the Center, one of its oldest non-releasable birds. During his stay he served as an education care bird, and was trained to perch on a gloved hand.

Randall had been paired with a female barn owl named Barni and together produced several clutches of owlets each year. The two also served as foster parents for orphaned barn owls. The healthy youngsters were all released into the wild.

Barni is about nine years old and, should another male barn owl be turned over to the Raptor Center for permanent care, is likely to have several more years of breeding left her.

Randall will be buried in the small cemetery at the Center.

If you or anyone you know would like to volunteer to work with the Carolina Raptor Center, contact them at 704-875-8814

Hunters Of The Sky Invade Uptown Charlotte

Raptors will fly into uptown Charlotte on January 26 as Discovery Place introduces its newest traveling exhibit, *Hunters of the Sky*. It will be at the museum through May 13, 2001.

Hands-on activities allow visitors to perch on the ledges of skyscrapers to view peregrine falcon nests, get an up-close look at a typical raptor meal and step into the role of wildlife rehabilitators. Visitors can even "grow" wings and learn what it takes to soar!

The Carolina Raptor Center will bring live raptors to the museum in February and March with a public show entitled *Face-to-Beak*.